

CASE STUDY

Case Study: ProBuild Supplies Ltd

Company Overview

ProBuild Supplies Ltd is a medium-sized enterprise based in the UK that specialises in the retail and rental of building materials and construction tools. The business operates from a single centralised site, which includes a retail storefront, a warehouse for inventory storage, and a tool hire division. The company primarily serves local builders, tradespeople, and DIY enthusiasts.

ProBuild's operations span three key domains:

- Retail sales of building materials and tools
- Tool hire services
- Customer loyalty and trade finance partnerships

Key Business Processes

1. Retail Sales Process

Customers visiting ProBuild can purchase tools and building materials directly from the shop or online. Stock availability is updated in real-time based on warehouse inventory. Products include items such as timber, insulation, plasterboard, power tools, fasteners, and adhesives.

Upon purchase, customers may choose delivery or click-and-collect. Delivery is managed via ProBuild's in-house logistics team, operating a small fleet of vans. Payments can be made through cash, card, or interest-free finance (available to eligible members).

2. Tool Hire Process

ProBuild maintains a fleet of rental tools including cement mixers, scaffolding, pressure washers, tile cutters, and heavy-duty drills. Customers may rent these tools for durations ranging from half a day to multiple weeks.

The tool hire process includes:

- Customer checks availability (online or in-store)
- Booking is confirmed, and payment or deposit is taken
- Tools are issued with a return date and condition log
- Upon return, tools are inspected
- Tools are sent for servicing to an external maintenance partner

Maintenance and servicing of rental tools are not conducted in-house. ProBuild has an ongoing contract with FixPro Ltd, an independent tool maintenance company, which collects and services tools on a weekly schedule. This ensures safety, compliance, and operational readiness.

3. Warehouse Management

ProBuild's warehouse is the operational heart of the company. The warehouse handles:

- Receipt of incoming goods from suppliers
- Stocking and binning of tools and materials
- Order fulfilment for both walk-in and online customers
- Tool hire returns and temporary storage before maintenance collection

The inventory management system (IMS) integrates with the POS (Point-of-Sale) system to maintain real-time stock levels. Staff perform daily stock checks and a weekly cycle count.

4. Trade Card Membership and Loyalty Programme

ProBuild offers a Trade Card – a paid membership scheme costing £10 per year. This card targets professional builders and regular customers. Benefits include:

- Access to interest-free financing
- Discount of up to 10% based on loyalty points
- Priority tool hire booking during peak seasons
- Points are accrued per pound spent and can be used to increase the discount band. Points reset annually.

5. Interest-Free Finance Partnership

For Trade Card holders, ProBuild has partnered with FinTrust UK, a third-party finance company, to offer interest-free purchases. This is applicable for eligible purchases above £100, on both tools and building materials.

When a Trade Card member opts for finance at checkout, their credit application is processed in real time by FinTrust. Once approved, FinTrust pays ProBuild the full amount upfront, allowing the customer to take their items immediately. The customer then repays FinTrust in equal monthly instalments over a period of six or twelve months. This seamless financing option has significantly boosted the average transaction size and strengthened customer loyalty among trade professionals.

External Maintenance Process – FixPro Ltd

ProBuild Supplies Ltd does not conduct any in-house maintenance of its tool hire fleet. Instead, it has established a service contract with an external specialist maintenance provider, FixPro Ltd, a certified tool servicing and repair company. The process is structured to ensure safety compliance, efficient turnaround, and minimal downtime for tools.

1. Weekly Collection and Drop-Off Cycle

FixPro operates on a scheduled weekly collection and return cycle, with a dedicated service vehicle visiting ProBuild's site every Tuesday morning.

- **Collection:** All tools that have been flagged for maintenance (post-return, post-damage, or routine service) are tagged and logged by ProBuild staff and stored in a designated "Service Bay" within the warehouse.
- **Handover:** A digital handover checklist is signed off between a ProBuild warehouse supervisor and the FixPro driver. This includes tool ID, condition notes, fault description (if applicable), and expected service type.
- **Return:** Serviced tools from the previous cycle are returned, accompanied by a service report for each item (including service type performed, parts replaced, next recommended service date).

2. Servicing Process at FixPro Ltd Facility

Once tools arrive at FixPro's central servicing facility, they go through the following internal process:

Initial Inspection and Diagnostics: Tools are inspected to verify reported issues and to check for additional faults. This includes electrical safety checks, wear analysis, and compliance verification.

- **Service Classification:** Based on inspection, tools are categorised as:
- **Routine Maintenance** (e.g. cleaning, oiling, tightening, calibration)
- **Repair** (e.g. motor replacement, blade sharpening, housing repair)
- **Out-of-Service** (beyond economical repair; flagged for decommissioning)

Servicing and Repairs: Qualified technicians carry out the required servicing using certified parts. If major repairs are required (e.g., replacements exceeding £50), prior authorisation is obtained from ProBuild's Tool Hire Manager via a remote portal.

Compliance Testing and Labelling: Post-repair, all tools undergo PAT testing (Portable Appliance Testing) and any other safety checks depending on tool type. A service label with date, technician ID, and next service due date is affixed.

3. Digital Reporting and Invoicing

Each batch of serviced tools is recorded in FixPro's client portal. ProBuild is granted access to the following reports weekly:

- Service Summary Report: Listing all tools serviced, work performed, and compliance outcomes.
- Exceptions Report: Tools that failed service or are due for replacement.
- Invoice Summary: Itemised invoice for labour, parts, and call-out costs.

ProBuild's systems are integrated with FixPro via an API that syncs the service records into the internal tool management database.

4. Quality Control and SLAs

The service level agreement between ProBuild and FixPro includes key performance indicators (KPIs) such as:

- Turnaround Time: 90% of tools serviced within 5 business days
- First-Time Fix Rate: Minimum of 85%
- Compliance Audit Pass Rate: 100% adherence to UK safety standards

An account manager from FixPro conducts a quarterly review meeting with ProBuild's Operations Manager to discuss tool lifecycle data, recurring issues, and opportunities to optimise the hire fleet.

Integration with Tool Hire Operations

Upon return from FixPro, tools are:

- Re-scanned into the warehouse inventory system
- Relocated to the "Ready to Hire" area
- Made available for reservation and rental again via the online system

This maintenance partnership enables ProBuild to maintain a safe, high-availability tool hire service without investing in in-house technical staff or complex workshop infrastructure.